

TROIKA!



A Complete Tabletop Role-Playing Game

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FREE!

Introduction

You are reading a tabletop roleplaying game (RPG) where one player takes the part of the gamesmaster (GM) who prepares the world, controls its people and peril, while the other players create characters on a journey through that same world. You now have the context and key terms to explore the medium independently, and nothing I say here can fully instruct you on what is a deep and rich form of entertainment on par with cinema or fly fishing. Treat as you would any new hobby.

Beyond that, what you have here is *Troika!*, a science-fantasy RPG in which players travel by eldritch portal, non-euclidean labyrinth and golden-sailed barge between the uncountable Crystal Spheres strung delicately across the Humpbacked Sky. What you encounter is anybody's guess – I wouldn't presume to tell you, though this book contains people and artefacts from these worlds which suggest the shape of things. The adventure and wonder are in the gaps; your game is defined by the ways in which you fill them.

Character Creation

Take a scrap of paper and record the following information:

1. Roll 1d3+3 to determine SKILL.
2. Roll 2d6+12 to determine STAMINA.
3. Roll 1d6+6 to determine LUCK.
4. Record basic possessions that every new character starts with: a knife, a rucksack, a lantern, a flask of oil, six provisions, and 2d6 silver pence.
5. Roll d6 on the background list and record your possessions and advanced skills.

Backgrounds

Backgrounds are everything your character was before you came along. Slide into the role and make it your own. Backgrounds only touch the edge of specificity: tailor them to the worlds you play in. Rework them or remove them entirely and replace them with your own unique vision of the Spheres. Boldly lay claim to the games you play, create recklessly, and always write in pen.

1. Claviger

The Key Masters wander the universe fathoming the workings of all entryways. Though they're quite fascinated with simple chests and doors, they are most excited by metaphysical and metaphorical barriers. You often find Clavigers encamped around the feet of demon gates, debating appropriate methods of attack and building obscure machines of entry.

Possessions

Festooned with keys (modest armour).
Distinguished sledgehammer (damage as maul).
Lock picks and related fine tools.

Advanced Skills

4 Locks
3 Strength
3 Trapping
2 Spell – Open
1 Spell – See Through
1 Maul Fighting
1 Spell – Lock

2. Monkeymonger

Life on the Wall is hard. One is never more than a few yards from an endless fall, yet those precarious villages need to eat. This is where you come in with your edible monkeys (the distinction is purely for appeal, since all monkeys are, of course, edible). You used to spend days on end dangling your feet off the edge of the world, watching over your chittering livestock while they scampered hither and thither, but there was no future in monkey meat.

Possessions

Monkey club.
Butcher's knife.
A pocket full of monkey treats.
1d6 small monkeys that do not heed commands, but are too scared and hungry to travel far from you.

Advanced Skills

4 Climb
2 Trapping
1 Club Fighting
1 Knife Fighting

3. Parchment Witch

Known for their smooth skin, midnight gatherings, and preternatural fear of rain and open flames, the parchment witches are long-dead sorcerers who cannot give up the vanity of life. They cover themselves in perfect paper skin, a painted and immaculately folded imitation of life intended to hide ancient bone and gristle.

Possessions

1d6 rolls of parchment.
Vials of pigments and powders. Collection of brushes.
Sword cane.

Advanced Skills

3 Spell – Protection from Rain
2 Spell – Callous Strike
2 Spell – Quench
2 Spell – True Seeing
2 Disguise

2 Second Sight

1 Healing
1 Spell – Undo

Special

You are undead, and so do not need to breathe or circulate blood. You take double damage from silver weapons and regain STAMINA half as effectively from all sources. You must TEST YOUR LUCK if exposed to rain or doused with liquid, or close to open flames, or if you suffer grievous wounds. A failure sees your skin ruined, which lets everyone see you as a walking corpse.

4. Rhino-Man

The original Rhino-Men were created by an insane sorcerer several centuries ago, but they rebelled and killed him. They are rare, and most often found serving as formidable and loyal guards to those who can afford their services.

Possessions

Horn (damage as knife).
Thick skin (modest armoured).
Undersized spear.
Tiny, useless helmet.
Knuckle dice.
Half-full firkin of rhino-beer (twenty provisions' worth).

Advanced Skills

3 Spear Fighting
2 Run
2 Strength
1 Gambling

5. Thinking Engine

Your eyes are dull ruby spheres; your skin is hard and smooth like ivory but brown and whorled like wood. You are clearly broken, you have no memory of your creation or purpose, and some days your white internal juices ooze thickly from cracks in your skin.

Possessions

Soldering iron.
Detachable autonomous hands, or centaur body (+4 run), or inbuilt particle detector (+4 second sight), or one random spell at rank three.

Advanced Skills

3 Golden Barge Pilot
2 Astrology
2 Pistolet Fighting
2 Healing
1 Run
1 Strength
1 Cooking

Special

You don't recover STAMINA by resting in the usual manner – instead you solder your flesh back together. For each hour of rest with access to the right tools you regain three STAMINA. You may recharge plasmic machines by hooking your fluids to them and spending STAMINA at a rate of one STAMINA and six minutes per charge. You always count as being at least lightly armoured.

6. Zoanthrop

At some point in your past you decided you didn't need it anymore: you found a zoanthropologist and paid them well to remove your troublesome forebrain and elevate you to the pure and unburdened beast you are today.

Possessions

No starting possessions; you have thrown off the shackles of civilisation. You are probably nude.

Advanced Skills

3 Climb
3 Run
2 Strength
2 Fist Fighting
2 Club Fighting
2 Wrestling

Special

You are immune to all mind-altering effects. You can speak, but usually choose not to. When making advancement checks for advanced skills related to abstract thought, such as spells or astrology, you must roll twice and succeed on both to improve.

The Rules

1. Rolling the Dice

Troika! uses only one die type, the d6. This can be used as a d3, d6, d66, d666, and so on. To roll a d3, roll a d6 and halve it, rounding up. To roll a d66, d666, or more, roll a d6 as many times, in order, as there are 6s, to generate the digits. So a d66 entails rolling a d6 followed by another d6 (e.g., if I roll a one then roll a four, I treat the result as fourteen).

To do most actions, roll 2d6, summing them: a roll under or a roll versus.

1.1 Roll Under

Rolling Under requires throwing 2d6 to score equal to or under a number. This is mainly for unopposed situations like climbing a wall or casting a spell. Rolling two sixes is a fumble and always results in failure.

1.2 Roll Versus

Roll versus, mostly used in combat or other contests, has two opponents throw 2d6 and add any applicable bonuses. The higher total wins. In a duel you might roll 2d6 and add your sword fighting total, looking to beat your opponent who does likewise.

2. Advanced Skills & Spells

Characters have a variety of advanced skills & spells granted by their backgrounds. The number given in the background plus the relevant SKILL yields the character's skill total.

2.1 Testing Advanced Skills & Spells

When a character wishes to do something where failure is possible you may test a relevant advanced skill. Most tests of advanced skills and spells are roll under, unless being actively opposed. See 12.0 for more on advanced skills.

2.1.1 When you successfully test an advanced skill or spell, put a tick next to it on your character sheet. These are used to improve (11.1).

3. Luck

Of all the numbers on your character sheet, LUCK will fluctuate the most. It represents your character's fortune and intuition, tested whenever fate swipes at you. When this happens, the GM asks you to TEST YOUR LUCK or suffer the consequences.

3.1 Testing your Luck

Roll Under your current LUCK score. Every time you TEST YOUR LUCK, reduce your current LUCK score by one whether or not the test was successful. Note, you may always refuse to roll and instead accept your fate. If the consequences of a failed LUCK test are not already obvious, the GM is not obliged to give you further details before you roll.

3.2 Gaining and Losing Luck

For every eight hours' rest, regain 2d6 LUCK. LUCK may not exceed the starting value, save for exceptional situations. Running out of LUCK inflicts no special penalty.

3.3 Use of Luck in Combat

In the case of a tie, you may TEST YOUR LUCK to break it in your favour. Before rolling damage, you may TEST YOUR LUCK and, if successful, add two to the damage roll.

3.4 Optional Rule: Luck Versus Death

If you find your games are too fatal and that the turnover of characters is too much to bear, you might allow characters who have died to TEST THEIR LUCK and instead be incapacitated, wounded, or saved by some bizarre twist of fate.

4. Stamina

4.1 Running Out of Stamina

When reduced to zero STAMINA, you must successfully TEST YOUR LUCK in order to survive. If you fail, you start dying. If this happens during an initiative round, then the next time the end of the round token is drawn, you die. If this happens out of initiative, you have one opportunity to save yourself (restoring you to one STAMINA).

4.2 Healing

Regain 2d6 STAMINA by sleeping for eight hours. Eat a provision to regain 1d6 STAMINA, up to three times per day. At your GM's discretion, there may be other forms of healing, such as drinking potions or visiting bath houses. You may never have more STAMINA than your starting total.

4.3 Negative Stamina

If you ever go below zero STAMINA, you are dead.

4.4 Death

Immediately make a new character, while others mourn your loss and fight over your possessions.

5. Initiative

5.1 Assemble the Stack

During combat, or at other times when it is important to know who goes first, the GM assembles the initiative stack. Prepare a container and a selection of initiative tokens such as coloured dice or other convenient markers (like cards, poker chips, and so on).

5.1.1 Assign each character two tokens of a single colour.

5.1.2 Add tokens to the stack for the enemies equal to those enemies' total combined initiative. For example, if you have eight Lizard-Men (initiative two), add sixteen tokens to the stack.

5.1.3 Add one token of a distinct colour to the stack. This token signifies the end of the round.

5.1.4 Optional Rule: Sometimes the player characters are grossly outnumbered. The GM may choose to limit the number of enemy initiative tokens to twice that of the player characters' tokens. For example, a party of five, with ten initiative tokens, is attacked by fifty goblins, who ordinarily have fifty initiative tokens; under this optional rule the goblins only contribute twenty.

5.2 Using the Stack

The GM shakes, stirs, shuffles, or otherwise randomises the initiative stack. Then, the GM removes a random token. The colour or design of that token determines who holds the initiative

and takes a turn. Consider giving players copies of their tokens, so they can easily keep track.

5.3 End of the Round

When the end of the round token is drawn, resolve any per-round or end-of-round activities, such as magic effects, drowning (7.9), fire, poison, or bleeding. Remove tokens contributed by dead characters and dead enemies and return all tokens of active characters and enemies and the end of the round token. Randomise the stack again, declare a new round, draw a new token, and continue.

5.4 Henchmen

Hired help willing to engage in combat each provide one initiative token to the stack. All Henchmen use tokens of the same colour and when a henchman token is drawn the GM determines who acts and what they do. The GM should take the wishes of the players under advisement but act in the best interests of the henchman.

5.5 Enemies

Enemies contribute a varying number of initiative tokens to the initiative stack, but these tokens all share the same design. Goblins have few tokens not because they are slow, but because they are cowardly; a dragon has many tokens not because it is fast, but because it knows exactly what it wants. When drawing an enemy initiative token, the GM declares that any one enemy acts, including an enemy who has acted previously this round. Obviously this can be abused on the GM's part. Never do this. Your goal is not to beat the players but to challenge and surprise them.

5.6 Rationale

The random length of the round adds uncertainty, because neither GM nor players know how much time or how many opportunities for action remain. When used outside of combat, the initiative stack represents hesitation, panic, or unexpected delays in a tense situation.

6. Actions

When you hold the initiative, you can generally perform one action. The following list is not exhaustive, and the GM is encouraged to interpret player intentions generously.

6.1 Hit Someone

To stab, bludgeon, or otherwise physically interfere with someone, roll versus your opponent. The winner of this rolls for damage (see 8.0) and the loser deducts from STAMINA the number generated. Either party in any exchange can potentially win. In a tie, both parties avoided hurting each other. You can potentially hit an

unlimited number of people in a round but can only initiate once per turn.

6.2 Shoot Someone

Shoot an opponent by rolling versus their SKILL or an appropriate advanced skill, such as shield or dodge.

6.2.1 When someone shooting into melee scores a hit, assign a number to every potential target and roll a die to see who receives the damage.

6.2.2 On your turn you may decide to take aim with your ranged weapon. To do so, hold onto your initiative token. When your next initiative token is drawn, you may roll twice and pick the better roll. If the end of the round token comes up and you haven't used your aim, you may hold it for the next round.

6.3 Cast a Spell

Each spell has its own instructions, but in general you need to spend an amount of STAMINA and roll under or roll versus. Unless stated, it requires at least one hand free and the ability to speak. If the result is a fumble, roll on the Oops! Table (located inside the back cover).

6.4 Delay

You may choose not to act when you hold initiative: mix your token back into the stack.

6.5 Move

Every action is assumed to have some movement involved. Anything less than four metres is folded into whatever else you might be doing. If you wish to chase after someone or perform some other involved locomotion, that takes your entire action.

6.6 Draw an Item

If you need to get something out of a satchel, case, or the like, roll 2d6 and compare the result to the item's position on your inventory list. If your roll equals or exceeds the item's position, then you can pull it out and do what you intended. Otherwise, spend your entire action finding it. Double ones always indicate a failure. Drawing an arrow follows this rule, so make sure the arrows are packed on top! See 10.3 and 10.4.1 for more on inventories.

6.7 Use an Item

If an item is in your hands, you may use it however you like (6.6).

6.8 Wrestle

Roll versus your opponent's wrestling skill. If you win, you may either knock the opponent to the ground or deal damage as unarmed and both fall to the ground. On a mighty blow (7.4), you

render the opponent unconscious for 1d6 rounds. If you fail, the opponent may damage you as a normal attack, and if you fumble (7.5), the opponent may deal you a mighty blow.

7. Other Concerns

7.1 Cover

A target with cover or concealment receives a bonus to any roll to avoid being hit at range. Let a waist-high bush grant +1 and a castle's crenellations grant +6.

7.2 Enemies

A typical enemy has only three numbers: SKILL, STAMINA, and initiative. Beyond this, an enemy may have one or two advanced skills or some peculiar special rules.

7.3 Hitting Someone Unawares

If your opponent is not aware of your presence, your attack is a roll under (1.1). Furthermore, the opponent may not attack back and you may add two to your damage roll.

7.4 Mighty Blows

Rolling double sixes while attacking strikes a mighty blow, winning the exchange and inflicting double damage (8.1). If both parties do this, a spectacular clinch is formed, shattering both weapons (in the case of beastly claws, tentacles, and so on they lose 1d6 STAMINA instead).

7.5 Fumbles

If you roll double ones in combat, you fumble, and your opponent adds one to the damage roll. If both parties fumble, each damages the other, adding one to the damage roll.

7.6 Shields

Shields reduce damage rolls against the wielder by one, to a minimum of one.

7.7 Use of Multiple Weapons

If you hit while using multiple weapons, you may choose which weapon inflicts damage.

7.8 Falling Over

When off your feet, you suffer -2 to all combat related rolls against those standing, including damage rolls. You must spend a turn getting to your feet.

7.8.1 For every two metres of uncontrolled fall, you lose 1d6 STAMINA when you land.

7.9 Drowning

When you fail a swimming test, lose 1d6 STAMINA as you begin to drown. For each consecutive failed test, roll an additional 1d6. For instance, your third failed swimming test in a row loses

you 3d6 STAMINA. Once out of STAMINA, you have drowned.

7.9.1 Any ongoing debilitating effects should be treated on the model of the drowning rules. Unless you have a specific effect in mind, victims lose 1d6 STAMINA per turn, with consequences becoming more severe. Improvisation is strongly encouraged.

7.9.2 Apply the ongoing harmful effects of drowning, fire, etc. only when the end of the round token is drawn.

7.10 Henchmen

Henchmen are created as you create monsters, with truncated abilities only covering their essence. See 5.4.

7.11 Time

The game has two main units of time: turns and rounds. A turn is what someone does when they hold initiative and is a few seconds long. A round is the period between drawing successive end of the round tokens and is roughly equal to one minute.

8. Damage

When you win a roll versus in combat, you inflict damage. Roll 1d6 and consult the Damage Chart (located inside the back cover) associated with your weapon. The result is the damage inflicted and is deducted from your opponent's STAMINA.

8.1 Double Damage

When striking a mighty blow (7.4), you double the damage inflicted by the damage roll.

8.2 Damage Modifiers

All modifiers that add bonuses to damage modify the roll of the die, not the damage inflicted. For instance, if I have +1 bonus to my damage roll and I roll a five, the result is six. Looking up the sword damage, a roll of six inflicts eight damage. A damage roll can be reduced to a minimum of one and has no upper limit for bonuses.

8.3 Unusual Weapons

You may use existing weapons to provide the Damage Chart of roughly equivalent exotic weapons, for example counting a rapier as a sword. This does not preclude making specific matrices for your inventions.

9. Armour

Armour protects your soft and supple body. There are four levels of protection, allowing you to assign an appropriate value to whatever assortment of pots and pans you might be wearing. You can be unarmoured, lightly armoured, modestly armoured, or heavily

armoured, reducing damage rolls by 0, -1, -2 and -3, respectively. A damage roll can be reduced to a minimum of one, no matter the armour's type.

9.1 Armour Encumbrance

Armour takes up a number of inventory spaces equal to twice its protective value. Thus, heavy armour uses six spaces. See 10.2.

10. Encumbrance

You may carry twelve things without issue. On your character sheet, you have twelve spaces to write these down.

10.1 Small Items

Some items are of inconsequential individual weight, like arrows, and only ever take up one slot unless you have an awful lot of them. What constitutes a lot is up to your group.

10.2 Large Items

A large item is anything you need both hands to hold. They take up two slots in your inventory; we recommend writing them at a jaunty angle to fill up the space. Armour has its own rules; see 9.1.

10.3 Retrieving Items in a Hurry

See 6.6. Note that having things near the top of your inventory list is advantageous, so put things you'll rarely need in a hurry, like armour and money, near the bottom. Pack your bags well!

10.4 Overburdened

If you carry more than twelve items, suffer -4 to all rolls. If you carry eighteen items or more, in addition you can hardly move and you count as unawares (7.3) if anyone wants to stab you.

10.4.1 If you want to unburden yourself quickly, roll 1d6. The result is how many slots of things you may safely put down this turn. At the GM's discretion, you may roll 2d6 if you don't mind your things getting broken or lost.

11. Getting Better

Life is learning, and you cannot experience it without growing in some way. When you successfully use a skill, you stand to learn from it. Tick it on your character sheet.

11.1 How to Advance

The next time you have a chance to rest and reflect on your journey, you may check to see what you have learned. Choose up to three ticked advanced skills or spells. For each, roll 2d6 and if the result exceeds your current skill total (see 2.0), you may increase this advanced skill or spell by one. Finally, remove all ticks from your sheet.
11.1.1 When an advanced skill total reaches twelve, you need to roll a twelve followed by

another twelve to improve it further. There is no upper limit to an advanced skill.

11.2 Learning New Advanced Skills

You must find someone willing to teach you who must have a higher skill total than you and they will most likely require payment. Training takes one week plus one additional week per rank you already have in the advanced skill. At the end of this time, you get one chance at advancement. To gain your first point when learning a new advanced skill, you must roll over your SKILL on 2d6 (precocious students are harder to teach).

12. Advanced Skill Descriptions

In most cases, the use of a skill is a straight roll under the skill total. Situations where this isn't the case should be obvious. For example, climbing over a high wall would be a roll under, whereas climbing a ladder while someone is chasing after you would be a roll versus.

Advanced skills are not limited to those listed here. There should be rarer fare available for those who search for it. Maybe a character feels driven to learn the intricacies of farming or opera.

You may notice some advanced skills in the backgrounds section don't have entries. Make those up. Don't be afraid of expanding the list and making them more and more specific.

Acrobatics

Used for rolling, balancing, falling, jumping, and so on.

Awareness

Anything worth having is well-hidden, so one must look carefully. Use this to spot traps, things normally hidden, or things out of the ordinary.

Climb

Most climbs require single rolls, though longer and more difficult climbs may require multiple rolls. Exercise discretion, and consider requiring some number of failures, total or consecutive, before a climber falls.

Disguise

The use of props to change your appearance. Roll under this skill when someone is liable to see through your disguise. It's opposed by awareness when under scrutiny.

Etiquette

When making a good impression is important, roll versus your host's etiquette. Represents a mechanical understanding of social conduct, and those who are better at it are more discerning.

Evaluate

Test this to get an idea of how much something is worth.

Locks

Allows a character to examine and open locks, but does not detect traps. Roll versus an imaginary locksmith whose skill is somewhere between six and twelve.

Mathmology

Gain insight into angles, pressures, numbers, and other such arcane arts. You could test mathmology to get a good idea of the surface tension of a ball of inert plasmic goo or to find the fulcrum for tripping a giant.

Second Sight

Allows the detection of magic. On a successful test, you focus your inner eye, and all sorcerous activity glows faintly for a moment.

Sleight of Hand

Steal or hide small things. You simply declare that you are hiding something and test only when the hiddenness is questioned.

Sneak

The art of remaining unseen. Test only when someone or something is actively searching for you. Roll versus the skill of searchers.

Strength

Used for lifting and breaking things. At the GM's discretion, may also be used to wrestle if they possess no more appropriate skill.

Swim

If you have this advanced skill, don't roll it for normal conditions. Test only when diving, swimming in dangerous waters, holding your breath for long periods, and so on. Characters without this skill are presumed unable to swim and must test swimming every round they remain in the water or they start drowning (7.9). For every two inventory slots filled, receive a penalty of one to swim.

Tracking

Used to stalk prey and find tracks. When stalking a quarry, roll versus the opponent's sneaking, tracking or the like.

Trapping

Use this to set and disarm traps. When setting traps, roll under your trapping advanced skill and describe how you make the trap with the materials at hand. Someone disarming a trap must roll versus the original trap-setter's trapping. If the GM doesn't know, assume six to be simple and twelve to be incredibly hard.

Weapon Fighting

When you take this skill, choose a general category of weapons. Roll versus during combat (6.1). The GM is encouraged to allow weapon categories to be broadly applicable, such as Glaive Fighting being equivalent to Polearm Fighting.

Other

If an advanced skill isn't listed here, make it up. Anything can be an advanced skill, from jousting to gambling to eating. Advanced skills are primarily flavoursome, to give characters chances to use their incredibly specific and heretofore useless abilities to help their friends into and out of trouble.

13. Items

13.1 Bonuses For Using Items

If an item is not listed, assume it adds a bonus of +1 to relevant rolls. Lockpicks, for instance, adds +1 to lock rolls, while a rope adds +1 to climb, and so on.

13.1.1 Item bonuses only apply if you are trained in the skill the item enhances. Lockpicks only give their bonus if you know how to use them (i.e., 1+ in locks already).

13.2 An Incomplete List of Desirable Things

A *fusil* is a long weapon that looks like a rifle and can be used in melee as a club. A fusil holds six charges before the plasmic core needs replacing.

Knuckle dice are made from the nimble, petal-shaped knuckle bones of goblins, which make excellent two-sided dice.

A *pistolet* is a hand-held energy weapon. Holds enough energy for eight shots.

Plasmic cores are crystalised starlight cast in metal. Or astral vapours captured in glass. Or maybe hard-ghosts? Whatever they are, they are pretty, and used as fuel sources for exotic weapons and reckless magicians. A plasmic core can be cracked open and huffed by a wizard in lieu of spending STAMINA on a spell. But if an Oops! Table roll is called for, the wizard has overdosed and drops dead instead, foaming at the mouth.

Pocket gods are little cloth puppets made in the image of your numerous gods. If you whisper a secret to one and throw it away, regain one LUCK.

Ruby lorgnettes are collapsible spectacles made with ruby lenses that require a free hand to use. Wearing them impairs your sight, but you see sorcerous activity clearly, granting +2 Second Sight.

The *velare*, when inactive, looks like an ornate piece of costume jewellery, usually a brooch or a circlet. When active, it produces a full-body disguise on the wearer formed from hard-light. Grants +4 disguise for twenty-four hours before needing to recharge from a plasmic core.

14. Spells

To cast a spell, you must spend STAMINA equal to the casting cost (the number in brackets), then roll under your skill total in the spell you wish to cast. Double ones always succeed, while double sixes always fail and require a roll on the Oops! Table.

Affix (3)

Cause an animate subject to be fixed in place. While so held, the subject does not move, breathe, fall, perspire, acquire, think, bleed, or otherwise change, and becomes, in fact, immune to all harm. Lasts for three minutes.

Amity (4)

The College of Friends always sends out its factotums on nights after amity classes. Clearing out the bars and brothels of their drunken apprentices is tiring work. Use of this spell causes the target to TEST THEIR LUCK or become agreeable towards the wizard, as though they were old friends. The target will not act irrationally, though, and if they were already a bit of a boor, amity might not change much.

Animate (2)

Cause inanimate objects to question their place. One object up to the size of a human baby may be induced to hop around and do whatever else the wizard wishes. Lasts until ended.

Assume Shape (4)

The wizard undergoes a distressing transformation into an inanimate object no larger than a piano and no smaller than a cup. Lasts until ended.

Babble (2)

The wizard speaks nonsense while watching the intended target, causing the target's words to trip and confuse. This may be cast under one's breath.

Breach (2)

The wizard's hands work elemental material – fire, stone, goo, earth, fog, all of it – as though it were soft clay. Lasts for nine minutes.

Brittle Twigs (2)

You snap a twig or other brittle object to cause an injury in another. They must TEST THEIR LUCK or suffer a broken bone.

Callous Strike (1)

The Wizard-Knights are most famous for their remote combat, whereby they swing their silver swords seemingly at nothing, only for their opponents, many metres away, to be torn to tatters. This spell can be used in place of a melee attack by rolling versus as normal, and inflicting damage according to the weapon used. May only be used against targets within clear sight.

Cockroach (5)

A popular spell that turns troublesome folk into humiliated animals. The target must TEST THEIR LUCK or be turned into an insignificant creature of the wizard's choice. Lasts forever.

Cone of Air (2)

Creates a mysterious cone of air focused on a touched subject's head. Regardless of other local conditions – vacuum, poison gas, deep sea, and so on – the subject may breathe the freshest of air for twelve minutes.

Darkness (3)

Exude a stationary sphere of darkness with a radius up to five metres for as long as three minutes.

Diminish (2)

Cause something to TEST ITS LUCK or reduce its size by half. Lasts three minutes.

Drown (4)

Cause a target's lungs to fill with water. They must TEST THEIR LUCK. If they fail, they start to drown (7.9) and are incapacitated as water pours from their mouth. They may test again once per turn until they pass, at which point the spell ends.

Earthquake (5)

Hike up your wizard robe and stomp your wizard feet. An area thirty metres around you suffers a massive earthquake. Everyone must TEST THEIR LUCK or fall through a crack in the earth, taking falling damage and being stuck in a bloody great big hole (7.8.1). Buildings may be wrecked unless especially sturdy.

Ember (2)

A simple but effective summoning of fire. Flames the size of a small bonfire appear somewhere within twelve metres of the wizard. Once present, there is no accounting for the fire's actions.

Farseeing (2)

Endows the wizard with engorged, plate-like eyes that are able to see in minute detail miles away, but are unable to see anything up close. Lasts until ended.

Fear (1)

In the eyes of one poor target, the wizard grows into a primal monster from the depths of the target's lizard brain. The target attempts to flee or curl up in a ball and whimper. They may TEST THEIR LUCK to resist the illusion.

Flash (3)

Clap neatly and issue from your hands the light of a thousand suns. All within twenty metres must TEST THEIR LUCK or be blinded for 1d6 minutes.

Gills (3)

The wizard may permanently gift a touched subject with gills, replacing the subject's usual breathing arrangement if they fail to TEST THEIR LUCK. Useful for underwater excursions but less so when inflicted upon a chap in the middle of town. The wizard may end this at will.

Grow (2)

Cause an item to grow half its size again if it fails to TEST ITS LUCK. Lasts three minutes.

Helping Hands (1)

From an inanimate surface, animate hands spring forth and perform any task the wizard requires. The hands are limited to being rooted to the spot from which they sprang. They last until the wizard wills the spell to end or leaves the area.

Invisibility (3)

The wizard turns flesh into refractive crystal sheets. It's very uncomfortable, and you make a slight shish-ing sound as you move, but are quite invisible and don't suffer from the usual limitations of illusions. Lasts for three minutes, after which you noisily reform into dull and frustratingly opaque flesh.

Levitate (2)

Elevates the wizard or another on the backs of tiny invisible sprites who answer only to their summoner. May float about for three minutes.

Light (1)

Create an ethereal orb of light that glows like a torch. Lasts six hours, and can be extinguished at will.

Lock (1)

Magically lock an object. The object must be capable of closure, but it is now magically sealed. Permanent until undone or dismissed.

Natter (1)

As everyone knows, wizards are excellent ventriloquists – so good, in fact, that they can throw their voices inside others' mouths. The

caster can target anyone within sight, and transmit a short sentence per casting.

Open (1)

The wizard chooses a reality wherein the lock was open all along. May be used to open any mundane door or container, or to counteract a lock spell.

Peace (2)

Open up the mind to universal love and cause two subjects to TEST THEIR LUCK or cease hostilities. They still defend themselves if attacked, but will at least appreciate the pettiness of it.

Protection from Rain (1)

This spell prevents the wizard from getting rained upon for one shower.

Quench (1)

Snuff a small flame with the wave of a hand.

Read Entrails (1)

The wizard can get the answer to one question from the entrails of a creature slaughtered for this purpose. The size and importance of the creature influences the level of knowledge gained. Small, common animals offer yes-or-no answers, oxen predict things obtusely, and lamassu offer explicit and thorough advice.

Read Stars (1)

Rather than physical stars, the wizard navigates by the astral starlight that peeks through the veil. This spell enables the wizard to get a sense of direction regardless of any obscuring factors.

See Through (1)

The wizard rubs a surface vigorously, making it translucent. Can penetrate up to thirty centimetres of material. Lead and silver are immune.

Shatter (3)

The wizard wildly gesticulates at a brittle object no larger than an umbrella and causes it to shatter into a million pieces. Living targets may TEST THEIR LUCK to avoid this unpleasant spell.

Sleep (2)

The wizard convinces a target to forgo wakefulness, causing the target to sleep until woken unless they successfully TEST THEIR LUCK. Remember: fighting is loud.

Starry Orb (4)

Create a five-dimensional orb above your head. All intelligent beings looking at it must TEST THEIR LUCK or marvel for three minutes.

Thunder (2)

Raise your arms and shout something suitably ominous. All within twenty-four metres must TEST THEIR LUCK or be deafened by a roll of thunder. Luck or no, they will be mightily impressed.

Tongue Twister (2)

Beware! If a wizard screws their nose and twists their fingers at you, then a Tongue Twister is coming your way. TEST YOUR LUCK or have your tongue literally tied in knots. This requires some time and a fair bit of patience to disentangle.

True Seeing (3)

Focus your sight on the unambiguous truth of matter, enabling you to see through illusions for the next ten minutes.

Undo (double cost of original spell)

Disentangle a spell from this instance of reality. To do so, you must successfully roll versus the original casting (if disentanglement is possible at all).

Ward (1)

A handy spell only requiring the flick of a wrist. In response to being fired upon, the wizard may cast this spell to deflect the missile.

Wall of Power (2)

What they call a wall is in fact a dome, but wizards have always worked in mysterious ways. The wall is a shimmering bubble that causes 1d6 damage when touched. Nothing may pass without the wizard's permission (it is recommended that you remember to allow air.) Lasts for twelve minutes.

Web (2)

Whether this spell opens a portal to the plane of slime or channels the sprites of sickness, all can agree that it is quite disgusting. You blow forth the 'web' from your nose, and all creatures in a cone extending twelve metres before you become trapped unless they TEST THEIR LUCK. Each turn, anything passing through or out of the web must repeat the test or become stuck. Dries up after twelve rounds.

Zed (?)

No one knows what this does but everyone who casts it disappears instantly, never to be seen again.

15. Enemies

The enemies that characters encounter are not like them – they are simpler machines that produce similar results.

15.1 Enemy Skill is Not Like Character Skill

Enemy SKILL covers everything that enemies lack, including advanced skills and LUCK. Enemies use the same number to climb a rope as to hit someone or cast a spell.

15.1.1 Enemy spells do not cost STAMINA.

15.1.2 Enemies do not spend LUCK. They don't have a LUCK score and instead roll versus their SKILL, which never diminishes. They cannot TEST THEIR LUCK to gain advantage in combat.

15.2 Why the Stamina Disparity?

The STAMINA of enemies tends towards lower numbers than characters. This speeds battles along and makes it fairer to characters who spend STAMINA for their magic. Note that the combat rules and damage are balanced so that a goblin is a threat no matter how much STAMINA it has.

15.3 Initiative is Different for Enemies

While all characters contribute two initiative tokens each, enemies have their own specific totals. These are all the same colour. When an enemy token is drawn, the GM uses it to take a turn with any enemy present. There is no limit to the number of times a single enemy may act in a round – indeed, you could have one enemy perform all actions drawn (see 5.5). For example, a lizard-man and a goblin are fighting the characters, and both enemies have contributed to the initiative stack. When an enemy initiative token is drawn, the GM may declare either enemy acts.

15.4 Armour is the Same

Rather than have varying types of armour, enemies just have a number. This is treated the same as the number associated with character armour, and represents physical protection, speed, incorporeality, etc.

15.5 Mien

If you have a plan for the enemies' attitude then go with that. Otherwise roll on their Mien Table to use as inspiration when playing them and to help avoid falling into routine hostility.

Bestiary

Alzabo

Skill 10
Stamina 21
Initiative 4
Armour 1
Damage as large beast

Mien

1. Hungry
2. Confused
3. Protective
4. Patient
5. Watchful
6. Evasive

The red-furred ghoulish bear, which at its shoulder stands as tall as a horse, would be a frightful

creature for its appearance alone, but an alzabo can imitate the voice of any creature it has eaten. Crying out in the night, it draws its prey from safety, typically by imitating a recently eaten family member and calling to that person's children or parents. Even if the devoured was human and those listening know that the cry is false, the sound of a daughter you know to be dead, scraping at your cottage door and begging to be let in from the cold, is more than most can stand.

Boggart
Skill 6
Stamina 9
Initiative 2
Armour 0
Damage as weapon or modest beast

Mien
1. Belligerent
2. Obstinate
3. Petulant
4. Insolent
5. Sullen
6. Smug

You could be forgiven for thinking a boggart was a rangy man with an exceedingly bristly beard, but no, once upon a time it sprang fully-formed from a hole, and has been ungrateful and ill-prepared for everything since. Boggarts rarely travel far from their birth hole, though no pixie compulsion keeps them there; it's more a point of principle and lack of imagination on their part. They can, if provoked, fight to defend the land they consider theirs, but they are prideful, stupid, and easily tricked.

Bonshad
Skill 12
Stamina 20
Initiative 3
Armour 2
Damage as gigantic beast

Mien
1. Wrathful
2. Virulent
3. Spiteful
4. Nauseated
5. Acquisitive
6. Imperious

While it is well known that the bonshads know the method of creating the Elixir of Shazmazm, it is less well known (at least amongst impatient apprentices) that *The 17th Incantation of Ignis Baxter: Bring Up What Bonshad Come* contains a typo in the fifth chorus. You can imagine the embarrassment this would have caused Master Baxter had he not been tragically caught up in the Oblation Wars soon after completing his seminal work. Regardless, calling up one of these hook-beaked and betentacled fiends without the reformed texts will see one dragged off to the bottom of the Demon Sea to work the bonshads' curious mines. What a lark!

Cyclops
Skill 9
Stamina 14
Initiative 3
Armour 2
Damage as large beast

Mien
1. Fearful
2. Depressed
3. Melancholic
4. Sombre
5. Resigned
6. Mercurial

Once upon a time, a nation of man asked one of the Aeons to grant them the power of immortality and foresight. The Aeons, being an arbitrary bunch, took one eye from each as fair exchange. The men found that their foresight was indeed present, but extended only to knowledge of their eventual deaths by accident or violence. Feeling positively monkey-pawed, they agreed to go their separate ways and to never speak of it again.

Special
When a cyclops is given initiative, it may draw the next three initiative tokens in order, thus granting it knowledge of who is going next. Cyclopes know when and how they die, and this might not be it.

Ekodat
Skill 8
Stamina 43
Initiative 3
Armour 2
Damage as spear

Mien
1. Dormant
2. Stationary
3. Unstable
4. Probing
5. Tentative
6. Cautious

The ekodat is a series of crystalline protrusions emanating from a clouded crystal core. These protrusions don't move, but grow rapidly through the air like roots or tentacles. Natural philosophers have been back and forth about the categorisation of the ekodat. While all agree it is a chimera of mineral and some other substance, they cannot confirm the type of that other. The popular theory is that the ekodat is a divine emanation caught and refracted in some unusually dense crystal matrix, causing what would otherwise be an angelic visitation to become a grasping, mineralogical hazard.

Special
The tentacles remain after an attack. When someone is injured by the ekodat, the victim is immediately attacked again by the sudden growth of additional spurs, as the spurs absorb the victim's vital fluids.

Goblin
Skill 5
Stamina 6
Initiative 1
Armour 1
Damage as weapon

Mien
1. Curious
2. Dismissive
3. Preoccupied
4. Gossipy
5. Overly Friendly
6. Paranoid

Goblins are the vanguard of civilization. The moment a Sphere bobs to the surface, the goblins creep out of its nooks and crannies to start expanding their labyrinth. Left alone, they will eventually tame and cover every surface in walls and hedges and tunnels and steel and whatever

else is in goblin-vogue, though more usually they become distracted by an accidentally awakened evil, or recalled by the Goblin King, or cut off from the centre of the labyrinth by civil wars and thus turned feral to live in the man-cities – a most terrible fate. Better to bury their labyrinths and leave.

Gremlin
Skill 3
Stamina 4
Initiative 3
Armour 0
Damage as small beast

Mien
1. Inveigling
2. Fearful
3. Fearful
4. Aggressive
5. Aggressive
6. Fake Inveigling

Vicious little creatures dressed in potato sacks they stole from an old mother's cupboards. When you see footprints in the pie crust, it's time to call the gremlin catcher, because where there's one there's a hundred, and underneath your home will be a maze of warrens stretching off to gods know where. No one has proven a link between gremlins' habit of appearing seemingly everywhere and the goblins' interdimensional labyrinth, but fingers are firmly pointed.

Knight of the Road
Skill 7
Stamina 7
Initiative 2
Armour 1
Damage as weapon

Mien
1. Curious
2. Wary
3. Drunk
4. Rowdy
5. Predatory
6. Friendly

Contrary to what the farmers tell you, the life of a vagabond is not an easy one. First you must find a road, but not a quiet road, or else you'll wait for weeks without a client, nor should it be too busy or else you'll no sooner have beaten the first about the bonce before another comes along and interrupts your exchange. After all that, you go back to your camp in the woods to sleep on the filthy ground and eat your meagre meals. Farmers should have more respect for a hard day's work.

Living Dead
Skill 6
Stamina 12
Initiative 1
Armour 0
Damage as weapon or modest beast

Mien
1. Oblivious
2. Pondering
3. Distracted
4. Hungry
5. Aggressive
6. Distressed

The definition of 'dead' varies from place to place. In some Spheres you might be considered dead when unconscious, but still living until buried. Now consider the ambulatory deceased, and the definition is even more nebulous and

near the point of irrelevance. Let's just say they have a fluid vitality.

Special
They take double damage from silver weapons.

Man-Beast
Skill 8
Stamina 11
Initiative 2
Armour 1
Damage as fusil or modest beast

Mien
1. Heedful
2. Observing
3. Watchful
4. Questioning
5. Challenging
6. Aggressive

The Autarchs couldn't rely on the aristocracy for delicate or controversial matters; even for thoroughly mundane requests, they were worshipful in word and recalcitrant in action. And so, towards the beginning of the reign, Autarch Gonand XXIII had a vizier fabricate armies of beastly chimaeras, loyal to the Phoenix Throne, obeying orders to the letter unto death. The man-beasts are far from mindless; they merely never question their lot in life, being unable to comprehend an alternative existence. Indeed, you might find man-beast guards still defending doorways to caches of the Autarchs' weapons and treasure, vigilant as sleepless, incorruptible watchdogs.

Manticore
Skill 12
Stamina 18
Initiative 5
Armour 3
Damage as large beast

Mien
1. Lazy
2. Bored
3. Hungry
4. Busy
5. Aggressive
6. Bored & Aggressive

Manticores are rarely encountered outside of their homes, which they tend to construct on mountainsides, far out of reach of the common folk. Kidnapped travellers, plucked from the backs of wagons or dragged from their inns during the night, attend them as servants. If a patron hires you to retrieve a stolen son from a manticore's manse, be sure to take some books. They are inveterate culture fiends, and love nothing more than having new literature for the help to read aloud to them.

Special
If a manticore strikes the same person twice in one round, then the creature's tail hits the target. The target must TEST THEIR LUCK or become paralysed for 2d6 minutes.



Owl
Skill 4
Stamina 4
Armour 0
Initiative 1
Damage as small beast

Mien
1. Curious
2. Watchful
3. Aggressive
4. Hungry
5. Guarded
6. Defensive

Owls crenulate the rooftops of Troika. They watch the streets with dumb spite, waiting for a vole, a rat, or an errant, fat finger to come to their attention. They swoop after it, followed by other owls thoughtlessly responding to the motion. Together they descend like a flock of razor-sharp gulls, impulsively grasping. A perennial nuisance that the citizens of Troika tolerate with morbid pride.

Piscean
Skill 3
Stamina 6
Initiative 2
Armour 0
Damage as modest beast

Mien
1. Mewling
2. Childish
3. Playful
4. Mischievous
5. Hungry
6. Starving

Legs of a man, torso and tail of a fish. They break into granaries, batter the nightguards with their blubbery tails, stuff their bellies full of feed, and run off into the night to digest in a local lake. Menaces!

Special
If a piscean incapacitates a party member, any pisceans nearby converge to eat the incapacitated person's provisions. Each piscean eats one provision per turn.

Tiger
Skill 8
Stamina 12
Initiative 2
Armour 0
Damage as large beast

Mien
1. Playful
2. Stalking
3. Hungry
4. Tired
5. Austere
6. Aggressive

It is common knowledge that all tigers come from the Palace of Tigers. You may see one in a jungle and think it is at home, maybe it's even raising kittens and leading a rich, full tiger life, but it is as alien to that forest as you or I, and the kittens are invariably stolen from lesser cats. Tigers were born to leisure, to bask in crystal solariums, and to stalk fat little coati in palatial gardens. Take pity on these angry animals, for they are lost and not used to your rude ways.



Tower Wizard
Skill 10
Stamina 12
Initiative 3
Armour 0
Damage as weapon

Mien
1. Offensive
2. Confused
3. Friendly
4. Suspicious
5. Inappropriate
6. Transgressive

Most sorcery enthusiasts are either members of colleges or respected freelance lecturers with manses in seaside towns – esteemed members of society who buy their groceries the same as us. However, when people think 'wizard,' they most likely think of the tower wizards, those feral academics who give up all pretence of civility and fled to the wilderness. There, they build their towers to work on unpleasant projects and terrorise anyone seeking their advice or endorsement. They give magic a bad name.

Special
The Tower Wizard has access to Ember and four other spells (random or chosen).

Troll
Skill 7
Stamina 12
Initiative 1
Armour 2
Damage as weapon

Mien
1. Rude
2. Standoffish
3. Spiteful
4. Disrespectful
5. Sarcastic
6. Sullen

Trolls are ill-tempered creatures, often spied leaning on pikes in the town square gabbing with the other guards, only taking breaks to shout at children or trip up old ladies. You'd think they'd stop hiring them.

Special
Trolls regenerate one STAMINA every time they hold the initiative. Even if reduced to zero STAMINA, they will eventually regenerate from anything other than decapitation or fire.

Weapon Damage Chart

DAMAGE ROLL	1	2	3	4	5	6	7+
Sword	4	6	6	6	6	8	10
Axe	2	2	6	6	8	10	12
Knife	2	2	2	2	4	8	10
Spear	4	4	6	6	8	8	10
Mace#	2	4	4	6	6	8	10
Polearm*#	2	4	4	8	12	14	18
Club	1	1	2	3	6	8	10
Unarmed	1	1	1	2	2	3	4
Shield	2	2	2	4	4	6	8
Fusil*#	2	4	4	6	12	28	24
Bow*	2	4	6	8	8	10	12
Pistolet#	2	2	4	4	6	12	16
Small Beast	2	2	3	3	4	5	6
Modest Beast	4	6	6	8	8	10	12
Large Beast	4	8	12	12	16	18	24

* Indicates a weapon that requires at least two hands to use.
Indicates a weapon that ignores one point of armour.

OOPS! Table

1. In a flash, you turn into a sentient animal of the GMs choosing.
2. An entirely different spell goes off, directed at the same target.
3. All currency in your pockets turns in to golden butterflies and flies off.
4. All shoes within half a mile catch fire.
5. You are launched in a random direction at great speed, landing fifty metres away.
6. All weapons of war in the vicinity turn into sunflowers.

Credits

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TROIKA!

TROIKA! is a science-fantasy role-playing game where you and your cosmopolitan group of fellow travellers explore the ends of the multiverse. You will fly on mystic barges, help dying gods, solve confounding crimes, plunder dead worlds, and meet strange & wonderful people.

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